Ministry of Housing, Communities & Local Government

Jim McMahon OBE MP
Minister for Local Government, Devolution and Regional Growth
2 Marsham Street
London
SW1P 4DF

Leaders in Surrey
By email

7 September 2026

Dear Leader,

I am writing to update you on the Local Government Reorganisation programme following the comments by the Prime Minister in the House of Commons last week that the government was prepared to look at decisions.

We set out in the Cabinet Statement on Rewiring the State that local government structures are key to our devolution ambitions and filling the map. Effective and sustainable local government is vital to meeting our ambitions.

However, the government has also listened to representations about the approach and pace of reorganisation. Those relate both to the specific decisions announced in March and July and to the scale and pace of the programme more broadly. While we recognise there will always be a wide range of divergent views on the structure of councils, and so achieving perfect consensus will never be possible, now is the time to pause and reflect. It is important that this is done right.

The Secretary of State will announce later today that we are undertaking a review of the Local Government Reorganisation programme and following updated legal advice (for the avoidance of doubt no privilege is waived) that she has withdrawn the decisions made in March this year for four areas: Essex, Southend-on-Sea and Thurrock; Hampshire, Isle of Wight, Portsmouth and Southampton; Norfolk; and Suffolk.

The review, which I will lead, will look at the programme as a whole and this will include reviewing the 14 decisions made in July. Cambridgeshire and Peterborough and West Sussex, where decisions have not yet been taken, will be considered as part of the review. The new councils for East Surrey and West Surrey are unaffected and outside of this process because they are already established in law, and you should continue you work on implementation to the existing timetable

Thank you for your continuing hard work to deliver local government reorganisation. If you have any questions about today's announcement my officials will be happy to help.

Yours sincerely,



JIM MCMAHON OBE MP
Minister for Local Government, Devolution and Regional Growth